

Play It Again, Evam

A bubbly young theatre company shows why the stage is not a dead-end in a world taken over by cinema and television

Not too many theatre companies in India can afford a 1,300-sq-ft office, and certainly not one that looks like an upmarket advertising company. But Evam can. Evam's office in the neighbourhood of Chennai's posh Chamiers Road is every bit of the plush set, the energetic young people calling the shots included. Adding to Evam's shine is that these people are MBAs and engineers, straddling technology and art, unlike regular theatre companies where hangers-on

Institute of Communications and Advertising. Kumar and Vishnu believe their biggest achievement has been establishing a brand, much like a corporate, and making it viable, not just sustainable.

Evam delivers what it promises: light entertainment. With plays like *Python Hysssteria*, based on the popular *Monty Python* series, a spoof adaptation of *Hamlet*, *Art*, *Love Letters* and the *Odd Couple*, their track record has earned them the

have an audience of more than 15,000 people across markets, and they keep us going," says Vishnu.

Going to an Evam show is a bit like going to an amusement park. And that's not only because of the smiley balls they distribute at shows, but because there's something for everybody. Gaming enthusiasts can look forward to playing a quick game at its venues, a move that has friends referring to them as the Disney of India, a title they prize highly. "I think of the audience as a guest at my sister or brother's wedding. It becomes my duty to make sure that they are taken care of," says Kumar, who with Vishnu has been nominated for this year's Pepsi MTV Youth Icon Awards, a first for the theatre fraternity.

Besides doing theatre, Evam will soon enter the world of cinema.



STAGED DELIGHTS

■ **Version One dot Oh:** The Bangalore-based theatre company has 15 productions, most of which are comedies.

■ **Akvarious Productions:** With 25 plays, the Mumbai-based group has professionals from the worlds of design and films.

■ **Dramanon:** The theatre group from Bangalore has managed to carve a niche for itself amongst the youth.

■ **Theatrician:** The Kolkata-based group has earned a name for itself in experimental theatre circuits with over 30 plays.

tend to be art students, struggling writers or wannabe actors.

In the usually impoverished world of Indian theatre, Evam, which means 'And' in Sanskrit, is a rare commercial success, with 15 productions and 200 shows in its five-year history. "Our philosophy is, you are your dream. If you want something badly, don't crib, go out there and make it happen," says 30-year-old Karthik Kumar, who co-founded the Rs 1.5-crore company with Sunil Vishnu, his classmate at the Mudra

CURTAIN RAISER: Team Evam; Vishnu (top right) and Kumar (sitting right)

reputation of being the Karan Johars of theatre.

What began as an initiative with zero capital, has grown into a company that hopes to touch a revenue of Rs 7 crore by next year. Evam tours extensively across south India and is also making its presence felt in Mumbai, Delhi and Kolkata. The team has 30 members, seven of whom are full-time employees. "We

Kumar has already worked in several Tamil films and stars in *Poi Solla Porom*, a *Khosla ka Ghosla* remake that has just hit theatres. Evam's biggest hit so far is *Five Point Someone*, and they have started work on another Bhagat bestseller *One Night @ the Call Center*. "We have big plans for *One Night @ the Call Center*—a 14-city tour across the country. It will be similar to rock band tours," says Kumar. Purists may frown and critics disagree, but Evam can't stop smiling.

by Nirmala Ravindran